

SpectrumReady Digital Guide

IEP Mastery

The Parent's Advocacy Bible — How to Get Your Child
the Education and Support They Deserve

\$47

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Important Notice — Please Read Before Proceeding

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Time-Sensitive Information. Government benefit amounts, income thresholds, and program eligibility rules change regularly. Dollar figures and thresholds in this guide reflect information as of 2025. Always verify current amounts and rules directly with the relevant federal or state agency before making any decisions.

Individual Circumstances Vary. Eligibility for the programs discussed depends on your individual circumstances. This guide describes how programs generally work — not whether you or your child specifically qualifies.

Consult Professionals. For decisions about your child's specific situation — including SSI applications, IEP disputes, insurance appeals, or estate planning — consult a qualified special education attorney, disability benefits counselor, or other licensed professional.

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Welcome: Why This Guide Exists

Every year, thousands of children with autism sit in classrooms with IEPs that don't actually meet their needs — not because the system is always malicious, but because parents don't know what to ask for, what they're entitled to, or how the process works.

The IEP is the single most powerful document in your child's educational life. It is **legally binding**. It determines what services your child receives, how many hours, in what setting, and measured against what goals. Getting it right — or getting it wrong — can change the trajectory of your child's development.

Part 1: Your Legal Foundation

IDEA gives your child **six core rights**:

Right	What It Means
FAPE	Free Appropriate Public Education — no cost to you, meets unique needs
LRE	Least Restrictive Environment — alongside non-disabled peers to max extent
Evaluation	Comprehensive, free, in native language, within 60 days of consent
IEP	Written plan reviewed annually, developed with your participation
Participation	You are a required member of the team — not a guest
Procedural Safeguards	Right to inspect records, seek independent evaluation, mediation, due process

LANDMARK CASE: ENDREW F. V. DOUGLAS COUNTY (2017)

The Supreme Court ruled that FAPE requires "meaningful" educational progress — not merely "more than de minimis." Use this precedent when the school proposes goals that seem too low.

Part 2: The Evaluation Process

How to Request an Evaluation (Template)

"I am writing to formally request a comprehensive special education evaluation for my child, [Name], DOB [date]. I am requesting this evaluation because [briefly describe concerns]. I understand I will receive a Prior Written Notice and Parental Consent form. Please confirm receipt of this letter."

Send via email AND certified mail. This starts the legal 60-day clock.

What a Complete Autism Evaluation Covers

- Cognitive/intellectual functioning
- Academic achievement (reading, math, writing)
- Social-emotional and behavioral functioning
- Adaptive behavior (Vineland, ABAS)
- Communication — expressive, receptive, pragmatic
- Occupational performance and sensory processing
- Autism-specific assessment (ADOS-2, ADI-R preferred)

Part 3: The 13 Required IEP Components

1. PLAAFP — Present Levels of Academic Achievement and Functional Performance

The foundation of the IEP. Describes where your child is right now, with specific data.

RED FLAG

Vague PLAAFP language like "Johnny struggles with social skills" with no data. Push for specifics: "Johnny initiates peer interaction in 2 of 10 observed opportunities and requires adult prompting 80% of the time."

2. Measurable Annual Goals

Every goal must follow this anatomy:

- **Who:** The student
- **Will do what:** Observable behavior
- **Under what conditions:** Context/setting
- **To what degree:** Measurable criteria (% , frequency, accuracy)
- **By when:** Timeline

Examples of Strong IEP Goals for Autism

Domain	Example Goal
Communication	"[Student] will use a 3–4 word phrase to make a request in 4 of 5 opportunities across 3 consecutive data periods, as measured by SLP data."
Social	"[Student] will initiate a social interaction with a peer at least 2 times per 30-minute unstructured period, in 4 of 5 consecutive school days."
Behavior	"[Student] will use a coping strategy (deep breathing, visual schedule, verbal break request) with no more than 2 prompts, in 8 of 10 opportunities."
Self-care	"[Student] will independently complete a 5-step morning routine using a visual checklist without adult prompting, in 4 of 5 school days."

4. Special Education and Related Services

Each service must specify: type, frequency, duration, location, start date. Common services for autism:

- Applied Behavior Analysis / Behavioral support
- Speech-Language Therapy

- Occupational Therapy
- Physical Therapy
- Social skills training
- Assistive Technology (AAC devices)

6. Accommodations and Modifications

Accommodations change HOW your child learns. **Modifications** change WHAT they learn. High-value autism accommodations:

Accommodation	Why It Helps
Extended time (1.5x–2x)	Processing time differences
Preferential seating	Reduces sensory distraction
Movement breaks every 20–30 min	Sensory regulation, focus
Visual schedule at desk	Reduces transition anxiety
Advance notice of changes	Reduces meltdowns from surprise
Noise-canceling headphones	Auditory sensitivity
Reduced homework load	Fatigue from masking all day
AAC device access	Communication support

Part 4: Placement Options

Setting (Most → Least Inclusive)	Description
Full inclusion in general education	With aides and supports
General ed + resource room pullout	30–50% of time in separate setting
Self-contained special ed classroom	Full day with peers with disabilities
Separate special education school	All special education population
Residential school	Live-in placement

LRE principle: Placement must be as inclusive as possible while still meeting the child's needs. The school cannot choose a more restrictive setting simply because it is more convenient or cheaper.

Part 5: The IEP Meeting Playbook

Before the Meeting

- ☐ Request copies of all assessments 2–3 weeks in advance
- ☐ Review current IEP — what worked, what didn't
- ☐ Gather private provider reports and letters
- ☐ Write your parent vision statement
- ☐ Prepare questions and service requests in writing
- ☐ Consider bringing an advocate

At the Meeting — Scripts That Work

OPENING STATEMENT

"Before we begin, I'd like to share my vision for [child's name]. I want [him/her] to [specific goal]. With the right support, I believe [he/she] can achieve this, and I'm here today as a partner."

WHEN A SERVICE SEEMS INSUFFICIENT

"I appreciate that recommendation, but [child's] private therapist has recommended [X hours/week]. Can we discuss why there's a difference, and what data supports the school's recommendation?"

YOU ARE NEVER REQUIRED TO SIGN AT THE MEETING

Take the IEP home. Review it. Consult an advocate if needed. You have 10 days to respond in writing.

Part 6: When the School Says No

Escalation Path

Level	Action	Cost	Timeline
1	Document everything in writing	Free	Ongoing
2	Request Prior Written Notice (PWN)	Free	Immediate
3	Facilitated IEP meeting	Free	2–4 weeks
4	State complaint	Free	60 days to resolve
5	Mediation	Free	30–60 days
6	Due process hearing	Attorney fees	45–75 days

Part 7: Autism-Specific IEP Issues

Behavioral Intervention Plans (BIPs)

If your child's behavior impedes their learning, the team must consider a Functional Behavior Assessment (FBA) and BIP. Most behaviors serve one of four functions: to get something, to avoid something, for sensory input, or for social attention.

RED FLAG

A BIP that is all punishment/consequence with no teaching of replacement skills. Push for a BIP that primarily teaches what to DO instead of the challenging behavior.

Extended School Year (ESY)

ESY = continued IEP services during summer. Most schools will not offer it automatically. You must: (1) Keep data on regression over breaks, (2) Bring data to the IEP meeting, (3) Formally request ESY.

Assistive Technology & AAC

For non-speaking or minimally verbal children, the IEP team must consider AAC. Research shows AAC does NOT reduce speech — it supports language development.

AAC Type	Examples
Low-tech	PECS, communication boards
Mid-tech	Proloquo2Go, TouchChat, LAMP Words for Life (iPad apps)
High-tech	Dedicated speech-generating devices (SGDs)

IEP Advocacy Toolkit

Questions to Ask at Every IEP Meeting

1. What data is being used to make this recommendation?
2. How will progress toward each goal be measured and reported?
3. Is my child receiving all services agreed to in the last IEP?
4. What additional supports would be added if current supports aren't working?
5. Are there any behaviors that need to be addressed in a BIP?
6. What does my child's school day look like from their perspective?

IEP Red Flags

- Goals that aren't measurable ("will improve social skills")
- No baseline data in the PLAAFP
- Services listed without specific frequency/duration
- Placement decided before evaluation is complete
- Meeting starts with IEP already written — you just need to sign
- Team pressure to sign at the meeting

Annual IEP Timeline Planner

When	Action
3 months before annual review	Review current IEP; request updated assessment data, draft parent vision statement
6 weeks before	Request evaluation results and draft IEP; contact private providers for updated reports
2 weeks before	Review all documents; prepare questions; identify non-negotiables
At the meeting	Follow the playbook; take notes; don't feel pressured to sign
After the meeting	Monitor service delivery; track goal progress monthly; address concerns in writing immediately

Key Resources

Resource	Where
Parent Training & Information Centers	parentcenterhub.org
Special Ed Law Reference	wrightslaw.com
Council of Parent Attorneys & Advocates	copaa.org

SpectrumReady

Empowering autism families with the knowledge they deserve.

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